

of them an SMS with the download link to some fake app infected with this same malware.

2. **Android.Trojan.GingerMaster:** GingerMaster is one of the first malware to use the root exploit (a vulnerability by which an app can gain admin access without having to install the rooted ROM). As the name suggests, it affects devices running the Gingerbread (2.3.3) version of Android. This enters a device when the user installs an app that's infected by this malware. Once it's in, it gains the root (administrator) privileges on the device, and publishes the device information (IMEI, IMSI, etc) to the command and control server. The attacker can also gain remote control of the device via this malware. It can also download and install apps without the users' intervention or awareness.
3. **Android.Trojan.FakeInst:** This is a nasty piece of malware that's hard to catch, and steals money. Like the fox in Little Red Riding Hood, it disguises itself as a genuine app. It can morph itself into a browser, an IM app, or even an antivirus, deceiving users into believing that they are installing genuine apps. Once installed, it sends SMSs to premium-rate numbers with or without user intervention. To avoid detection, it can change its icon and its file size (by inserting images).
4. **Android.Trojan.FakeDoc:** Let's admit it; when it comes to smartphones, we're all looking for ways to optimise its battery performance. This malware takes advantage of the universal desire to get our smartphones to last another day without a recharge. This comes free with the app Android Battery Doctor, and has the capability to upload your Personally Identifiable Information (PII) to the control server. This information may include your device IMEI, device location, OS version, Google account information, etc. The link: <http://goo.gl/Vmjfm> explains in detail how this malware works. A must read!
5. **Android.FakeApp:** This malware explores the concept of the evil twin. The attacker creates an evil twin of a legitimate app, and publishes it on the Google Play Store using a different publisher ID. Though these fake apps have a short lifespan, as they are easily identified as rogue apps, they can still create havoc. When a fake app is installed, it bombards the user with advertisements, collects personal information, notifies the user of other apps by the same publisher, and it can also push the app on social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter.
6. **Android IRCBot:** Discovered in May 2012, this malware comes in with the game Madden NFL 12, and has three components, apart from the main dropper component (used to deploy other components): Linux/Exploit-Lotoor.a (malware that discovers root exploits available on an Android device), Android/IRCBot.a (IRCBot malware) and Android/SMS.gen (SMS-sending malware that works similar to Android.Trojan.SMSSend). Since it is a 3-in-1 malware, it is also thrice as devastating. It can steal your money, grant remote access to your device and publish all PII stored on the device on IRC. A detailed analysis of this malware is given at <http://goo.gl/7lbt0>.
7. **Android/MarketPay.A:** Another money-stealing malware, it sits in the background and has the capability to purchase apps on its own, without your knowledge. It works in a very neat manner—initiates a purchase request, and as a result of this request, a confirmation code is sent by the app store. This code is intercepted by the malware, and it authorises the purchase. Upon successful purchase, it deletes all the remaining evidence (like billing messages, purchase confirmation message, etc) from the device.
8. **Android/Funbot.A:** This one is a critical threat, as it can turn your device into a zombie machine (aka a botnet client). Like any botnet client, it talks to the command and control server to take instructions, through which files can be downloaded or uploaded to and from the device. It also gives an attacker the power to explore the directories of an infected device. Coupled with any of the above malware, it can be used to launch an Advanced Persistent Threat (APT). This kind of malware can also be used to conduct corporate espionage (gathering information about competitors, using illegal means), cyber warfare and other purposes.
9. **Android/Backscript.A:** Here's an advanced Android malware that can update itself even when it's in the wild. Being a botnet client, it talks to the command and control server to get updated commands and functionality. At the core of it is JavaScript to provide the self-updating facility.
10. **Android/Plankton.A:** This malware was discovered in June 2011. Upon its discovery, it was found that ten apps, available on Google's Play Store (then Market Place), were infected by this malware. When inside the device, it is launched as a service. It collects information about applications installed in the device, its security settings, etc, and sends this to a server over HTTP. This server returns the URL of a JAR file, which is downloaded and executed. Using this technique, it can bypass all the application checks enforced by app stores. A detailed analysis of this malware is given at <http://goo.gl/mABfR>.

Bonus read: PlaceRaider—visual malware

Though this article was about the 10 deadliest Android malware, this one's worth a mention. A team of curious